

Anarchist Political School

Racism, colonisation, and Indigenous struggle



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The Anarchist Political School is a project of the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group. For more information, check out our website melbacg.au



Race and prejudice

To discuss racism, it is necessary to distinguish between some related, but separate concepts: **race**, **racial prejudice**, and **racism**.

The idea of **race** proposes that the human species is divided into different races, and that these races have a biological origin. This biological racism has been debunked by science. We utterly reject the idea that humans can be divided into some number of biological races based on differences in skin colour, hair, and so on. There are no genes that make up race. The superficial biological differences that do exist between historically geographically separated groups of people do not match up with the socially constructed categories of race. There is simply no biological basis to the category of race.

Racial prejudice describes incorrect generalisations or judgements about people based on ideas of race. People can have prejudices against virtually anyone where they perceive some category of difference. These are character flaws to which humans are susceptible to in certain circumstances. Decent people usually reject the principle of racial prejudice and try to eradicate it from themselves.

Discuss

Why do ruling classes promote the idea that humans can be divided up into races?

Racism

Racism is something different to prejudice. Racism is a form of systemic oppression in which one group of people are oppressed and often exploited by another, and where the oppressed group are defined and selected on racial grounds. Racism functions as a means of organising and justifying the oppression of large masses of people.

The State, acting on behalf of the capitalist class, has been central to creating and maintaining racism. Throughout the history of capitalism, the state has created and fostered racism by granting favoured groups relative privileges, whilst imposing disadvantages on targeted groups. These forms of racism have always been ways of dividing and controlling groups of people.

Racism is used by capitalism in several important ways. Racism allows the ruling class to create a comparatively marginalised segment of the working class who are then hyper exploited (e.g. paid less and forced to work in

more dangerous conditions than the rest of the working class).

Meanwhile, the favoured group in any racial hierarchy (e.g. white men) is co-opted into defending the state and ruling class. Large plantation owners in the American South, for example, could never have dominated huge populations of enslaved people without enlisting the rest of the white population into the task of violently dominating enslaved people. The dominant group in a racial hierarchy appears to benefit from it, but this is an illusion. Racism makes the ruling class rich, but divides the working class and ensures that workers cannot unite to fight our common class enemies.

In the workplace, bosses use racism to pit groups of workers against each other, and undermine attempts to unite and fight for higher wages and safer working conditions. Outside the workplace, racism, xenophobia and nationalism are manipulative tools used by the state to justify war and imperialism, and to send workers off to fight in the interests of the state against other groups of workers.

Discuss

Can there ever be such a thing as “reverse racism”? In Australia, could a First Nations person ever be said to be racist towards a white Australian?

Migrant workers

In Australia, workers without permanent residence are at a disadvantage in relation to their employers and the bosses know it. This applies doubly if the workers are undocumented or working outside their visa conditions. This leads to some occupations being dominated by immigrants receiving much less than the minimum wage.

The horticulture industry in Australia, for example, is built on the hyper-exploitation of migrant workers and refugees. The official minimum wage might be \$23.23 an hour, but in fruit picking, migrant workers routinely work for piece rates that amount to as little as \$8 an hour.

As a result of racialisation, bosses can work people harder and for lower wages, while using the fear of replaceability to keep white workers in line. Certain jobs (cleaning, back-of-house hospitality, meat packing, fruit picking, etc) become racialised, while capitalist media spin narratives of migrants “stealing jobs” and drum up racist myths about violent crime.

Under the threat of deportation, migrant workers on temporary visas are often in too precarious a position to fight back against extremely exploitative conditions. To

undo this, we need to fight hard against the abusive visa system that exists in Australia today.

Discuss

Why do both the Labor and Liberal parties police Australia's borders so violently with boat turnbacks and modern concentration camps for refugees?

The historical origins of racism

Modern racism has its origins in merchant capitalism and slavery. Merchant capitalists established slave plantations in the Americas and elsewhere to extract resources from the new European colonies. A massive slave trade developed to supply enslaved African people to labour on the plantations. Europeans justified slavery on the grounds that the people they enslaved were less human and undeserving of freedom.

It is important to understand the cause and effect of racism and slavery. Slavery generated racism. Racism did not cause plantation owners to enslave people. Plantation owners enslaved people in order to get rich and racism was generated as the justification.

Capitalism has continued to generate, change, and shape racism to suit its needs. Racist ideas that were developed to justify slavery in the 17th and 18th

centuries were readily adapted to justify settler colonisation and genocide in the 19th and 20th centuries and neo-colonial wars in the 21st.

Discuss

Where can we see examples of racist ideas being generated by the ruling class today to justify war, militarism and genocide?

Colonisation and Australia

The national myth taught in schools is that Britain colonised Australia in order to create a dumping ground for convicts. In truth, prison labour was exported to Australia in order to begin the colonial project. The colonial project in Australia was always about expanding the power of the British empire and extracting resources that could be exported back to Britain to fuel industry.

First Nations people were not a class society. In many other areas of the world, colonising powers sought to conquer and co-opt existing class structures, and use those class structures to dominate and exploit Indigenous people. In Australia, there was no ready made system of exploitation and extraction that the British could co-opt and take over, so instead they embarked on a project of settler colonisation.

The logic of settler colonialism is extermination. In order to extract resources, the colonial power needs control over land. Indigenous people never freely surrender the basis of their own existence, their land. The colonial power, therefore, seeks to destroy Indigenous people and permanently dispossess them of their land. Another word for this is genocide.

Historically in Australia, colonisation took the form of massacres, sexual violence, disease, poisonings and starvation. Today it looks like child removals, mass incarceration, deaths in custody, political and military oppression, the erosion of land rights, and the denial of sovereignty.

The same dynamics that drove genocide, dispossession and settler colonialism in Australia from 1788 continue today. When Aboriginal peoples demand land rights, they run straight into the interests of mining and pastoral capital. Large segments of Australian capital are still built on the basis of colonial style extraction.

To this very day the expansion of mining, fossil fuel extraction, agriculture and logging is built on the ever greater dispossession of Aboriginal people. Rio Tinto blows up sacred sites like the Juukan Gorge to expand iron ore mining. The Victorian government cuts down sacred Djab Wurrung trees to expand a highway. Not to mention every other aspect of Australian capitalism is

built on the continuing dispossession of the already dispossessed.

Discuss

Should non-Indigenous workers today consider themselves as settlers? What about migrants or refugees who come to Australia?

Decolonisation and Self-Determination

Genuine Blak self-determination threatens the basis of Australian capitalism. Therefore, the struggle for Indigenous self-determination can only be won through a social revolution against the State and capitalism.

If the State and capitalism are left in place, any movement which overthrows colonialism will leave in place all other forms of oppression that exist under capitalism.

Decolonisation in Asia, in Africa, and South America has repeatedly shown this to be the case. The direct racist rule of the old ruling class is ended, but the workers and peasants of these countries continue to live impoverished and unfree lives. Highly repressive regimes of local capitalists continue to allow the plunder of their country by imperialism and profit handsomely in the process.

As anarchist communists, we say that freedom means something much more than life under capitalist governments. In fighting struggles against apartheid, colonialism, and imperialism, we argue that the working class must take the lead, with its own methods of struggle.

National oppression can only be eliminated by the working class, very much including First Nations peoples, taking control over their own lives.

Discuss

Will a capitalist state ever truly recognise First Nations sovereignty? What does this mean for the struggle for treaty?

White Australia and the labour movement

As the colonial population in Australia expanded with the gold rushes, colonial politicians were dealing with a serious issue for all ruling classes: how do we maintain control? How do we prevent the working class from becoming rebellious? How do we contain their discontent?

In 1851, over 10,000 migrants from 23 different countries rose up during the Eureka rebellion in Ballarat.

The ruling class needed to reassert control. One of the key solutions for the colonial elite was the idea of White Australia and ever greater attacks on Chinese migration. By demonising and oppressing Chinese migrants, the colonial ruling elite was able to co-opt white migrants, and deploy them in defence of the colonial project against the "yellow peril".

One of the first pieces of legislation passed by the newly formed Federal Government in 1901 was the Immigration Restriction Act (popularly known as the White Australia Policy). White Australia was the official position of the Australian government for over 65 years, and was only officially renounced by the Whitlam government in 1973.

The White Australia policy aimed to stop Asian immigration and limit non-white immigration (including people from the south of Europe), in order to keep Australia 'British'.

The unions and the Australian Labor Party (ALP) adopted the racist propaganda of the ruling classes. The mainstream white labour movement was deeply racist, and advanced the idea that the new Australian state was a utopia and a working man's paradise. Paradise was not open to non-whites and working women, who were deemed inferior.

The powerful, rurally based Australian Workers Union (AWU) represented the mainstream of the Australian labour movement. They regarded antipathy toward Asia as central to the maintenance of high living standards. By restricting non-white immigration they sought to keep wages and living conditions for white (male) workers comparatively high. Despite declining living standards in the 1920s, the AWU and its allies remained loyal to White Australia.

The Industrial Workers of the World (IWW) pilloried the AWU as “Australia’s Worst Union” and stridently opposed both White Australia and the Labor party. The IWW made active efforts to recruit Asian workers and translated their publications into several languages. The IWW was destroyed by police repression.

Discuss

It is often said that the White Australia policy never really ended in practice. Where can we see its modern equivalents today?

Defeating racism

Racism is a necessary part of maintaining capitalism. Unless capitalism is overthrown, capitalists and the State will continue to regenerate racism to defend their interests. This means that any strategy for defeating

racism not only requires fighting for anti-racist reforms like prohibiting the use of police firearms or the right for all migrants arriving on a work visa to have the right to apply for a permanent visa on arrival, but it also requires a programme of revolutionary class struggle.

First Nations peoples, fighting alone, have limited power within capitalism. In order to win the fight for Indigenous self-determination, it will require a united working class movement committed to overthrowing capitalism.

It will require Indigenous and non-indigenous workers standing side by side against racism, the State and the bosses. We have seen examples of this kind of struggle throughout Australia's history.

In August 1966, around 200 Gurindji workers at Wave Hill cattle station walked off on strike, not just in protest of their horrendous working conditions, but also for the return of the land to Aboriginal control. The strike received support from rank and file unionists around Australia who provided food and other necessities to the Gurindji workers, allowing the strike to endure until 1975.

In 1972, a block of houses in Redfern, Sydney was bought by a development company IBK who planned to knock down the houses, evict the tenants and build expensive townhouses in their place. Aboriginal families

had lived in these houses for decades and begun buckling down to resist evictions by the police. The Builders' Labourers Federation (BLF) also stepped in to support the Aboriginal community. Union workers in the BLF not only refused to demolish the houses, but they also did repairs, and fixed up the plumbing and electricity in the Block for free.

Sixty-five homes were saved, providing the Aboriginal community with affordable housing. Factories in the nearby area were also repurposed into a medical centre, a preschool and a cultural centre.

Discuss

How can we fight against the mass incarceration of First Nations people today? How can we resist the policing of Indigenous communities?

Working Class Unity

But white workers should not fight for non-white workers simply out of altruism. The fight against racism is essential to building independent working class power. For as long as capitalism is able to pit segments of the working class against each other in defence of a false racial hierarchy, the rule of capital will remain secure. The workers, divided, will certainly be defeated.

Racialised workers remain under-represented in most unions in Australia today – a product of the racist history of the labour movement. Unless this barrier is overcome, and the unions commit themselves to fighting against racism, the Australian labour movement will remain hampered.

This leads to a two-way conclusion for anarchists. On the one hand, in order to defeat racism, we must overthrow capitalism. And in order to overthrow capitalism, we must build up the power of the trade union movement. So fighting racism requires building up the power of the unions, and pushing them to fight for the immediate struggles of racialised workers.

On the other hand, in order to build the unions, we must fight racism. No union will be effective unless it can unite workers together, regardless of their race, gender or sexuality on the basis of “touch one, touch all”. Much like fighting sexism or queerphobia, fighting racism is not something that can wait until “after the revolution.” Quite the contrary, the only way that we will successfully bring about a revolution is if we commit ourselves to fighting racism now.

Discuss

How can we practically go about defeating racism in our political and mass organisations?

